Despite the end of the Yuan dynasty, the Mongols continued their close association with Tibet. For example, it was a Mongol chief, Altan Khan, who bestowed the honorific Dalai on his guru, Sonam Gyatso (1543–1588 CE). The honorific was posthumously applied to two earlier chief lamas of the Yellow Hat sect, the Gelugpa, which was established by the great teacher and reformer, Tsongkhapa (1357–1419 CE). It was again another Mongol chief, Gushri Khan, who helped the fifth Dalai Lama become the undisputed religious and secular ruler of Tibet in 1642.

The Hans, in contrast, played no role in Tibet. During the Ming dynasty, which was an ethnic Han dynasty, Tibet was not a part of the empire, though the Ming emperors (as mentioned in the previous chapter) sent several diplomatic missions to the country and bestowed several honours and gifts in pretence of being the overlord. These missions were mounted precisely because of the fear among the Ming rulers that their Mongol adversaries may use their Tibetan connections to attack the empire. These ritualistic gestures are now being interpreted as the Ming inheriting Tibet as a Chinese fiefdom.

Even during the subsequent Qing empire established by the Manchus (more on the Qing in Chapter 12), also a non-Han polity, the Mongols continued to be a major influence in Tibet. The region known as Dzungharia was ruled in the seventeenth century by the Oirat Mongols, a branch descended from the original Mongol lineage of Genghis Khan. Dzungharia at this time consisted of the northern part of the present Chinese province of Xinjiang, bounded by the Altai mountains to the north and the Tianshan mountains to the south. The Dzunghar khanate also extended into the western part of Mongolia and the eastern part of present-day Kazakhstan. Tibet was not directly ruled by the Mongols but was part of their empire. It was in 1641–42 CE , under Gushri Khan, that Tibet was unified and placed under the rule of the fifth Dalai Lama. Gushri Khan was declared the Chogyal or the Dharma emperor by the Dalai Lama, thus continuing the Yuan dynasty practice of appointing the Sakya Pandita (now replaced by the Dalai Lama) as the imperial preceptor, or the royal teacher. This is also the origin of the Tibetan insistence that there was only a patron–